

Name: _____

Date: _____

Australian Curriculum v9.0 Aligned | AC9E6LY04 | Year 6 | Complex Texts, Perspective & Sustained Argument

LEARNING INTENTION

I am learning to analyse complex texts by examining perspective, evaluating evidence and constructing sustained, well-reasoned arguments.

READING STRATEGY

Identify the author's perspective and purpose. Evaluate the quality of evidence. Consider whose voice is missing. Challenge assumptions and construct your own reasoned position.

READ THE PASSAGE — READ IT 3 TIMES!

Modern zoos present themselves as **conservation** centres, research institutions and educational facilities.

Yet critics argue that confining wild animals to **artificial** enclosures — however spacious — is fundamentally unethical.

Proponents point to success stories: the Arabian oryx was **declared extinct** in the wild in 1972 but was reintroduced after successful zoo **breeding programs**.

However, opponents note that fewer than 1% of zoo species are actually **endangered**, and most will never be returned to the wild.

Studies of **cognitive** animals such as elephants, primates and dolphins reveal that captivity causes significant **psychological distress**.

Elephants in zoos live on average 17 years — wild elephants live up to 70.

Arguably, the billions spent on zoos could more effectively fund **habitat** preservation and anti-poaching programs.

The question is not simply whether zoos are nice to visit, but whether they can be **morally justified** in the 21st century.

VOCABULARY HELPER

conservation = the protection of animals, plants and natural environments

cognitive = relating to mental processes like thinking and awareness

psychological distress = emotional suffering affecting mental health

habitat preservation = protecting the natural environment where animals live

morally justified = able to be defended on ethical grounds

WARM UP — BEFORE YOU READ

Do you think keeping animals in zoos is justified? Write 2 sentences giving your initial view:

A — COMPREHENSION

1. What do modern zoos claim to be?

2. Give one argument **FOR** zoos from the text:

3. Give one argument **AGAINST** zoos from the text:

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Answer Guide (For Parent / Teacher Use)

Warm Up: Accept initial personal view.

A1. Conservation centres, research institutions and educational facilities. **A2.** Arabian oryx saved from extinction. **A3.** Fewer than 1% of zoo species are endangered / captivity causes psychological distress / shorter lifespan. **A4.** Zoo elephants live 17 years vs wild elephants up to 70.

B1. Slightly against — more space given to counter-arguments and the final rhetorical question challenges zoos. Evidence: 'however opponents note' is developed at length; the final sentence questions moral justification. **B2.** It is the strongest counter-argument to critics — shows zoos CAN save species — but the author immediately qualifies it with statistics.

C: 'Arguably' signals this is the author's opinion, not fact — hedging language. Final sentence: reframes the debate from enjoyment to ethics — a rhetorical technique that challenges the reader to think more deeply.

High Five! You are a Super Reader! ✓
Colour a star each time you read the passage aloud:



EXTENSION ACTIVITY

Write a formal debate speech (for or against): 'Zoos should be abolished in the 21st century.' Include a hook, 3 arguments, a counter-argument rebuttal and a powerful conclusion.

PARENT TIP

Visit a zoo and ask critical questions: 'How big is this animal's natural habitat? Is this enclosure adequate? What conservation programs does this zoo run?'

TEACHER TIP

Structured debate: half the class argues for zoos, half against. Students prepare arguments, rebuttals and closing statements. Discuss how to argue ethically about animal welfare.

STUDENT REFLECTION

- ☐ I can evaluate whether a text is balanced or biased
- ☐ I can explain the purpose of rhetorical techniques
- ☐ I can construct a 3-point sustained argument using evidence